

**DISTANCE**

3 mi

**TIME**

1.5 hrs

**ELEVATION GAIN**

600 ft

**SEASON**

Spring, Summer, Fall, Winter

**HIKE INFO****WEATHER**

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*The Grotto Trail is a short hike to one of Southern California's classic hiking destinations. An easy route that can extend as far as you want, with great opportunities for climbing and a wonderful place to refresh your bouldering skills.*

The drive up the coast to the Santa Monica Mountains is one of my favorites. The skies were clear, the surf in the Pacific was choppy, and a steady breeze filled the

air with that great salt scent. When I got to the Circle X Ranch, I couldn't resist grabbing a shot of Exchange and Sandstone Peaks with the ranch's flagpole:



If you are interested, the ranger / info station at the [Circle X Ranch](#) offers some occasional interesting ranger-led programs. They're happy to answer any questions you might have about the area ... and they have a water fountain and flush toilet if you need it.

There are a few ways to reach the Grotto – you can also hike in from two different trailheads for the Canyon View Trail further east along Yerba Buena Road. For this trip, start at the Circle X Ranch parking area and begin your hike

From the parking lot on Yerba Buena Road, I could see clear down to the narrowing canyon walls of my destination. Unlike many hikes in the Santa Monicas or San Gabriels, the Grotto Trail starts up high and ends down low. So while it will be easy going in, just remember that it's all uphill on the way out.